

1 GOD'S WISDOM

In order to discuss financial management properly, I need to back up and start with the source of all wisdom, God's Word. I'd like to bring into focus the difference between how God says we should handle money and what the world has been teaching us about handling money.

I have been a Christian for about 19 years, prior to which I was a non-Christian for about 30 years, including the first 11 years of my marriage. My wife, Judy, and I were a typical young couple. She came from a fairly well-to-do family, and I came from a fairly poor-to-do family. I thought that she would be a spendthrift, and therefore I sought to control all the finances in our marriage. As you might imagine, we argued—a lot. You might say we had communication problems. Most of them related to finances, and yet we never really lacked money. Ours was a lack of understanding about how God uses opposites in a marriage. But I'll come back to that later.

When we were first married, I would remind my wife (regularly) not to leave lights on, to turn the heat down, and not to leave the refrigerator door open. It wasn't really a conscious thing. It was really my defense against what I presumed to be her latent desire to cost me money. One time, without her knowing about it, I unscrewed the light bulb in the refrigerator so she would think the light had burned out. Now that's pretty cheap.

In fact, when we were first married I would tell Judy, "I'm a basically frugal person," especially when she mentioned buying clothes. Once, a couple of years later, she said, "You're a basically cheap person and there's a difference." Ever since that time, I have tried to be frugal, but not cheap.

I now realize that God has put Judy in my life to help provide the balance I need, and vice versa. Without her I would never buy furniture, and without me she would never change the oil in the car, both of which are necessary.

We were both unsaved when we got married. Consequently, we had only experience to fall back on in working out our